

SURVIVAL IN A SMALL TOWN MOTEL

O.K. There's only one motel in town, there's no kitchenette units, and you have a four week residency. The local cafe has a few good dishes but you're mostly into grains and vegetables. Motel owners frown on electric hot plates and fry pans because of grease spattering and fire danger. In this all too common situation, the crock pot/slow cooker is the perfect artists companion. Along with a small electric water boiler for making tea or coffee, one can survive quite nicely. Here's some ideas.

A crock pot (think of it as a portable oven) with the removeable crock is best, but since it's hard to wash something that large and heavy in a motel sink, I usually use a smaller pan that fits inside the crock. One of those spattered blue enamel pans with a wire handle is just right. What you can cook depends a little on whether you can come home at lunch time because some things cook in 2-6 hours. Baked potato, winter squash, or rice only take 2-4 hours depending on quantity and size. A whole chicken takes about 6 hours on low. Frozen foods like meat pies, vegetables, french fries, fried chicken etc. can be heated up in two hours on high. A cheese omelette/souffle cooks in 45 minutes to 1 hour. I make one at night while the pot is still hot from dinner, and eat it at room temperature for a quick but sustaining breakfast.



Use the low setting for all day or all night cooking, and the high setting for faster action. It takes 20 minutes to $\frac{1}{2}$ hour for the crock to heat up. Spray the pan or bowl you are cooking in with PAM for non-stick cooking and super easy cleanup. (It's just lecithin.)

GRAINS - Rice, millet, wheat berries, buckwheat, etc.

$\frac{1}{2}$ cup grain and 1 cup water plus pinch of salt.

cook on low for 3-4 hours, high for 2-3 hours

Variations: Use bouillion cubes, slice vegetables like onion, succini, broccoli, etc. on top of grain for last hour of cooking.

Oatmeal- $\frac{1}{2}$ cup long cooking oats, 1 cup water and apple chunks, raisins, cinnamon. Assemble at bed time, turn on low and wake up to a good hot breakfast.

MEAT - Chicken, whole or pieces, stewmeat, chuck steak, etc.

Put meat and any vegetables desired in the pan in the morning.

Set on low and enjoy your meal at the end of a busy day.

EGGS - Can be stirred together and mixed with anything leftover (potatoes, grains, veggies) plus cheese for a great quick meal.

45 minutes to 1 hour on high. They can always be cracked onto a bed of tomatoe sauce and baked whole. Something between fried and poached.

TORTILLAS AND PITA BREAD - Wrap several in foil and rest package on top of inner pan (which, presumably holds dinner) for $\frac{1}{2}$ to 1 hour.

BEANS - Beans can be heated in the can (open first). It will taste a little better if you have a little more energy, you can open the can and dump the contents in to the inner pan and cook for one hour. Beans, corn, ravioli, stew, etc.

COOKED CAKES - Small packages of cornbread, muffin, or other mix can be used. Bake on high for 2-4 hours, depending on how deep the batter is in the pan. Frozen rolls and waffles take 1-2 hours on high.

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MOTEL SURVIVAL (cont.)

BEANS - Soak overnight and cook all day on low.

NOODLES - Trickey, but it can be done. Don't use egg noodles.

Pre-heat pot to very hot. Boil water in water boiler. Pour into inner pan. Add noodles. Pour off extra water when cooked. Add any sauce to taste.

Cous-cous is very easy to cook. Pour $\frac{1}{2}$ cup boiling stock onto $\frac{1}{2}$ cup cous-cous. Let set for 5 minutes. Fluff with fork and eat with butter, cheese, spaghetti sauce, or even honey.

Handy items to have on hand - Parmesan cheese, bottled spaghetti sauce, soy sauce, salsa.

A FEW RECIPES

SPOON BREAD - Cut corn off one fresh ear of corn.

Pour 1 cup boiling water onto $\frac{1}{2}$ cup cornmeal.

Stir 'till smooth.

Add 2 tbs. butter, $\frac{1}{2}$ cup milk, and 2 eggs (that have been mixed together) Salt and sugar are optional.

Add cut corn.

Stir well.

Pour into pan and bake on high for 3 hours.

RATATOUILLE - cut a small eggplant into chunks and sprinkle with salt to pull out bitter juices.

Put 1 chopped onion with some oil or butter into pan.

Turn on high.

After $\frac{1}{2}$ hour to 1 hour, rinse and dry eggplant.

Add to pan along with 1 sliced zucchini and 1 or 2 tomatoes and green peppers.

Cook 4-6 hours on low or 2-3 hours on high.

There it is. Quasi-gourmet cooking in a motel room.
Enjoy yourself.

Try out new ideas *and share them with me.*
You are what you eat.

Jeannie M. Lerie